Anxiety! At the Glimbow

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/39862461.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

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by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

Bow is about to go back to summer camp as a counselor. He's looking forward to seeing his friend, Glimmer, there because he's got a big question to ask her. Of course, big questions come with big answers and Bow's just a bit nervous about what the answer may be.

Created for the 2022 Summer Glimbang prompt, Follow Your Arrow.

Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the work for more notes

Bow stood in his cabin looking at his hair in the mirror. He loved the style the barber had done for him. It had been one of the last things he'd done before he'd left for camp and he grinned as he remembered what he'd told the barber as he sat in the chair.

"I need a special haircut, please," Bow said as the barber got the apron adjusted.

"Well, that I can do," the barber, Tony, had said as he leaned back against the little station that held his tools, "but you need to be a bit more specific. I'm guessing we're not doing the typical close shave for camp?"

Bow looked at himself in the mirror as he felt his heart beat a little faster.

"Well, I'm bringing my clippers along so it'll end up like that before the summer is over," Bow said. "I need something else though for when I get there."

"You need a special hair cut just to show up? Not quite getting it," Tony said and then saw the look on Bow's face. "Ah, never mind. Yes, I do. What's the lucky person's name?"

Bow looked up at him in surprise as he said, "Wait, how did you know that?"

“Son,” Tony said as he stood up and patted Bow on the shoulder, “I’ve been cutting hair for almost forty years. It’s obvious what’s on your mind.”

Bow gave a shy smile as he shrugged.

“OK, yeah, her name is Glimmer,” Bow said.

“I remember you talking about her. She know?” Tony asked as he turned around to pick up some scissors and the clippers.

“That I’ve got a thing for her?” Bow said and then answered. “No. Well, I don’t think so. I’m going to tell her as soon as I can.”

Tony nodded as he started walking around Bow, eyeballing his head.

“Nervous?”

Bow hadn’t been but then he felt a huge lump settle in his chest as he just nodded.

“Well, no worries there,” Tony replied. “I’m going to make you look so good she’ll be enthralled with you just from your haircut.”

Now standing in front of the mirror in the cabin, Bow looked at the hair and felt that lump again as he wondered if he was making the right choice. He took a deep breath and made a gesture like he was pushing the tension out.

"She feels it too," Bow said with a nod of his head at his reflection. "I know she does. This is just confirming it. You can do this."

He looked at the small clock on the wall he'd made a few years before, made note of the time, and started getting ready. His dads had given him all kinds of advice when he'd told them what he was planning and Lance had even tried to get him to take a bottle of cologne with him.

"It's nice cologne," he'd said as Bow had laughed at him.

"It really is," George had replied. "I picked it out for him myself. I think she'll enjoy it."

Bow had just shook his head as he said, "It's a great scent, really, but it's a floral scent."

Lance had suddenly looked uncomfortable as he'd replied, "I'm sorry! I have something more masculine if you want that!"

Bow had been confused for a moment and then realized he'd accidently implied that Lance hadn't thought of Bow being trans.

"Hang on, it's not that. I'm going to be at camp. Floral scents attract bugs. It won't be romantic if we're sitting in a swarm of bugs who think I'm a giant flower."

"Well, you'll be a very masculine flower," Lance said.

Bow grinned as he shook his head and said, "Thank you but really, I'll pass. Besides, I'll have bug spray on anyway. It won't be a good combination."

"You could pull it off," Lance had replied as he set the bottle of cologne to the side.

"Now remember, you should let her parents know as soon as possible," George said.

"Dad, that's a bit conservative of you," Bow said in confusion. "I'd think she can make her own decision in this."

"It's not that," George said. "You work for them and if all goes well, you'll be dating their child, who also works for them. They might have some rules they want you to follow for decorum."

"OK, that's understandable," Bow said.

"Your first girlfriend," Lance said with a smile. "I'm so happy for you."

"She hasn't said yes yet," Bow said, feeling the nerves settle in again.

"If she doesn't, it's her loss," George said, leaning forward to squeeze Bow's shoulder.

Now, as Bow finished getting ready, he wondered again about this whole thing. He'd been friends with Glimmer ever since he'd first started coming to the camp. They'd been in the same cabin and had immediately bonded. They'd spent every moment they could together and when he'd transitioned, the only thing that had changed was the cabin he'd been staying in. Now he looked at himself in the small mirror as he adjusted his binder and made sure his favorite crop top was sitting just so as he tried to psych himself up.

"It's going to be the same as always, except with kisses," Bow told himself. Then he remembered that Glimmer occasionally smooched him on the cheek and felt his face get hot. "OK, different kisses, kisses on the mouth…"

Bow found himself suddenly not thinking and just staring in the mirror, a little smile on his face. Then he shook himself, clipped his

camp radio onto the belt of his shorts, and headed out the door. He immediately saw Sea Hawk walking towards the camp docks with his arms overflowing with life vests.

"Bow!" Sea Hawk hollered from inside his little self-imposed cocoon of life vests.

"Hey, buddy!" Bow said, raising an arm in greeting.

"You want to hang out later?" Sea Hawk said. "I got some new songs I want to try out on the guitar!"

"Can't today, going to be hanging out with Glimmer," Bow said, trying not to grin too much at the thought.

"Not a problem! Both of you come by! Mermista may be making an appearance as well! I'd love an audience!" Sea Hawk said.

"I'll see what she says," Bow said diplomatically. "Do you need some help with those life vests?"

"No! Only three more trips to go from the supply shed," Sea Hawk said as he started walking again.

“You know you can use the golf cart and its trailer, right?” Bow said.

“No fun in that!” Sea Hawk said as he kept going. Bow just shook his head as he went on as he followed the little dirt road that led from the clusters of cabins back in the woods towards the main camp. He grinned as he saw a few ripe sand plums on a cluster of bushes right before he came out into the open ground of the main camp. Glimmer had taught him about them when he’d first come to camp and they’d eaten themselves sick on them at first. It was still a special thing between them so he plucked a handful of them.

It was headed towards evening as he crossed the main grounds. The sun was low and casting long shadows in the still air. Bow appreciated the early summer air, warm but not yet the furnace it’d be in just a few weeks even at this time of the evening, and he took a deep breath to appreciate the mingled smells of dust, cut grass, a breath of moist air from the river, tarred wood from some posts in the ground, and just something that made him think camp. It was relaxing and he felt himself grinning, excited to see his friend.

He was headed for the archery range, where he’d spend a good portion of his time during the summer, and where he’d agreed to meet Glimmer. He turned down the path, headed back into some trees, and as he did so, he got a glimpse across the river at the religious camp that sat on top of the bluff on the other side. The guy who ran the place had given Glimmer’s parents some grief over various issues but Bow just kind of felt curious about the people who went to camp there. He’d see them up on the bluff, going about whatever it was they were doing, and try to imagine some little story for them. As he walked into the trees, he figured

he’d probably never know if he was right or not but that didn't really matter.

Finally, after a little more walking, he got to the archery range. There was a narrow pavilion with raised tables that marked firing stations under it. There’d been talk of laying concrete under it off and on for a while but Bow rather liked the sandy soil that was there. A small shed behind it held all the archery equipment. He saw the door was open and a target had been set up downrange. Standing at a firing station with a bow stretched back and an arrow knocked stood Glimmer. Bow felt the lump of nerves drop into his stomach at the sight of her as she let the arrow fly. The arrow went wide, completely missing the target, and buried itself into the ground a few dozen feet behind the target with several others. He saw a few arrows sticking out of the target and grinned, even through his nerves. Glimmer never had been a very good archer.

“I can hear you back there judging me,” Glimmer said as she turned around and sat the bow down on one of the raised tables.

“Well, I’ve only told you like a dozen times you have to be more consistent with how you shoot,” Bow said as he walked forward. “And your stance is off.”

“It’s the equipment,” Glimmer said, poking at the bow on the table. “The arms are warped on this one.”

Bow sat the sand plums down next to the bow and picked it up. He looked at it, nodding, as he said, “Maybe.”

Then he picked up an arrow, nocked it, and let it fly, all in one smooth motion. As the arrow hit the bullseye he turned to look at Glimmer.

"Show off," Glimmer said with a grin as she stuck her tongue out at him.

"I'll be sure and check all the equipment closely before I let the campers use it," Bow said with a grin back at her.

"Are the plums for me?" Glimmer said as she picked one up and took a bite.

"Nope," Bow teased. "I thought I'd just carry around a handful of them for no reason."

Glimmer ate the small fruit before tossing the seed into the bushes behind her as she came around the table with her arms out. Bow hugged her tight as they rocked back and forth for a moment. While she lived at the camp and Bow only lived a couple of hours away, they didn't get to see each other much during the year. Bow's heart started beating a little faster as he held her and the smell of sunblock and insect repellent she was wearing worked up his nose. The hug broke and Glimmer jumped up on one of the tables as Bow picked up a plum and started eating it.

“Alright, so you gotta tell me, you and Perfuma going to be a thing again this summer?” Glimmer said with a grin. Bow froze for a second, plum in hand, before giving a thin smile back.

“Come on, we weren’t even a thing last summer,” Bow replied. “We just had a lot of the same schedule and ended up hanging out.”

“I know, I know,” Glimmer said as she held her hand out and Bow automatically put another plum into it. “I just gotta tease you about it.”

“I remember you getting irritated about it last year,” Bow said with a little raise of his eyebrow.

“I wasn’t irritated,” Glimmer said with a shake of her head. Bow watched the short cut hair and thought about the times he’d helped braid it or put it up for Glimmer. He cleared his throat as Glimmer went on. “I just wanted more Bow time, that’s all.”

Bow smiled at her as he said, “Well, I’ll happily give you all the Bow time you want. Of course, since you’re in charge of the scheduling this year, that should be within your grasp.”

“Hey, I’m taking that responsibility seriously,” Glimmer said. “That’s why I’ve got time built in for us just to hang out. It’s important.”

Bow laughed as he said, “Seriously?”

“No,” Glimmer said with a sigh. “Mom still has final approval.”

“You tried to slip it past her, didn’t you?” Bow said.

“Yes! I didn’t think she’d notice Planning Session in the list of things,” Glimmer said with a huff as Bow handed her the last plum. “Of course, I only had you and I in it so she immediately spotted it. ‘You have a big job, Glimmer,’ she said. ‘You can’t just be hanging out with your friend all the time.’ It was just an hour in the afternoon!”

“Just?” Bow said.

“OK, fine, and some time in the morning after breakfast as well,” Glimmer said.

Bow laughed and then remembered what he had planned that evening and his laughter died away to be replaced by the ball of nerves in his stomach. Glimmer didn’t notice as she ate the plum. Bow looked around at the fading light of the sun as cicadas started buzzing in the undergrowth. He took a deep breath and was about to say what he felt when Glimmer tossed the seed into the brush and spoke first.

“So whatcha want to do tonight?” she said as she turned to look at him. He almost blurted it out right then and there but lost his nerve.

“Ummm, well, Sea Hawk invited us over. He’s got some new songs he wants to try,” Bow said, as he waved a bug away from him.

“Ooooo, Sea Hawk invited us over. You finally got your invitation,” Glimmer said with a laugh. “I can grab a bottle to play Spin the Bottle on the way over if you want.”

“I am never telling you my crushes again,” Bow said.

“I’m just teasing,” Glimmer said, leaning forward to rub his arm. “I don’t want to watch you play Spin the Bottle with Sea Hawk.”

Bow thought he could hear something in her voice. The sun had gone down and while the sky was still bright with twilight, it was dim under the pavilion and her expression wasn’t certain.

“Well, you have an idea?” Bow asked.

“My Aunt Casta is down from the commune,” Glimmer said. “We can probably get some embarrassing stories about Dad from when they were growing up and play some games on the back porch.”

Bow thought about it. At the moment, being around Glimmer's family where he couldn't easily say what was on his mind sounded like a really good idea. He realized he was chickening out but he didn't care at the moment.

"That doesn't sound bad. Let's do that," Bow said, a little too fast.

"You alright? We don't have to if you don't want to," Glimmer replied.

"No, it's fine," Bow replied. "Really. I haven't seen Casta since last summer."

Glimmer nodded as she said, "OK."

She hopped down off the table and put up the archery things before locking the shed.

"Going to get the target and arrows?" Bow asked.

"Can we come out in the morning and get them?" Glimmer said.

"Yeah, we can do that," Bow said. "So your place is the plan?"

“Yeah, Casta will be thrilled. She asks about you constantly. She’s knitted you some socks and stuff so fair warning,” Glimmer said.

“Why would I need a warning?” Bow asked as the two started walking. “I love her stuff. It’s so comfy.”

“I notice you didn’t say visually appealing,” Glimmer said with a laugh. Bow laughed with her. One of the things that Casta did at her commune was make yarn from the sheep they raised and dye it with natural dyes. The yarn that got used for Glimmer and Bow was often bad batches that didn’t take dye well and wouldn’t sell but Bow couldn’t complain. It’s not that it looked terrible but it was certainly unique.

“I think it looks just fine,” Bow said. “The sweater she gave me right before the end of camp last year was nice and comfy. I wore it all winter.”

“I remember,” Glimmer said. “You were wearing it when you came up on your winter break. It looked good on you.”

Bow again thought he heard something in her voice but just said, “Thanks.”

They walked in comfortable silence, taking a trail shortcut towards Glimmer’s house when Bow saw some fireflies flitting through the trees. He stopped to watch them for a minute and Glimmer stopped with him as they both leaned up against a huge

cottonwood tree as the little bugs flashed around them. Bow could see the stars overhead coming out as twilight faded from the sky and suddenly he felt Glimmer leaning into him. He could feel the warmth of her arm against his and his heart started beating faster.

Just ask her, he thought. Bow looked down in the darkness just as Glimmer's head rested on his shoulder. He swallowed hard as he tried to get his tongue to work so he could speak.

"Ummm… Glimmer… can I ask you something?" Bow managed to get out.

"Sure, what's up?" Glimmer said as pulled her head off his shoulder and looked at him.

"So, you know, you've been there as a friend for me for a long time, and you were there for me when I came out as trans," Bow said and trailed off. He'd had a whole thing he'd wanted to say but it was all gone from his head now.

"OK, yeah, I know," Glimmer said, looking at him. He could just make her face out in the darkness and took a deep breath.

"Well, I've been thinking about you a lot lately… you know… a lot," Bow said, feeling his face go hot. Then he stopped as Glimmer stepped up a little closer.

“Bow?”

“Yes?” he replied.

Glimmer reached up and put her hand against his cheek. His eyes went wide as he looked down at her.

“I think about you a lot too,” Glimmer said.

“Are you saying…,” Bow said but again trailed off as she put her other hand along his other cheek.

“I am, yes,” Glimmer replied. “Are you?”

“Yes, I am,” Bow said, nodding a little.

Glimmer smiled a little as she said, “So… uh… kiss?”

“Kiss,” Bow said, not able to say anything more as he leaned down. The kiss wasn’t what he’d been expecting though. It was so much better. Time passed, although neither one noticed until they ran low on air. As they pulled their heads apart, Bow’s arms wrapped around Glimmer and held her close as she did the same.

“So, ummm, I guess we’re dating?” Bow said, trying to say it smoothly and utterly failing.

Glimmer laughed as she leaned forward and bopped her forehead against his as she said, “We better be.”

Bow was going to say something else but he figured kissing her was so much better than talking so they did that again. However, the problem with kissing along a trail at a summer camp, even one that didn’t have campers in it yet and only the staff, was that people tended to use the trails. Bow wasn’t sure how long they’d been leaning up against the cottonwood when they heard a long drawn out, “Wooooooo!”

The two broke apart and looked down the trail to where it turned and saw two counselors standing side by side who were beginning to clap.

“I told you, Spinne!” one of the women said. “I win the pool!”

Spinne rolled her eyes as she said, “We didn’t have a pool, Tossa, and I mostly agreed with you.”

“OK, hold on,” Glimmer said. “You all have been talking about Bow and I?”

“Yeah! The whole staff!” Tossa replied. “We figured you’d two end up together eventually. Bow, you should have waited! I could have won a lot more if you had!”

“We didn’t have a betting pool!” Spinne said with a laugh. “Bow, I honestly thought you’d go for Sea Hawk but hey, I’m happy to be wrong.”

“OK, you two,” Glimmer replied, “get going before I reassign you both to nothing but awful tasks.”

“Such a tyrant!” Tossa said with a laugh as she and Spinne started walking again. Bow was doing alright with the whole thing until Tossa high fived Glimmer on her way past.

When they left, Bow turned to Glimmer and said, “A high five? Really?”

“Hey, if you wanted this to be a hidden romance, you picked the wrong person to date,” Glimmer said with a smirk. “I am going to make this the first morning announcement tomorrow.”

Bow looked at her as a little firefly flew between them.

“I don’t want to hide this at all,” he said with a little smile.

“Good answer,” Glimmer said as she kissed him again. “Now, as much as I’d love to stand out here in the woods making out with you, we should probably go tell your bosses that you’re dating their daughter.”

“Ok, hold on, making out is a bit… wait, your parents?” Bow said as he caught up to what she was saying.

“Don’t worry. Mom and Dad love you,” Glimmer said. Bow could feel the little lump of anxiety sneaking up on him again but then he looked down at Glimmer.

“I’m not worried. I know you’ll be there with me,” Bow said.

“Another good answer,” Glimmer said and pulled his head down to kiss her again.

End Notes

I have no idea why I called this Anxiety! At The Glimbow. The original title I put in was Panic! At The Glimbow and it was always meant to be a placeholder. Then I got to this point, of actually posting, and I couldn't think of something else so I just changed it a bit because there's no panic here. Anyway, this is for the 2022 Summer Glimbang.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!